

Cover story PAKISTAN

civilian target came even as US Secretary of State Hillary Clinton arrived in Islamabad for a three-day visit to demonstrate American support in Pakistan's dark hour, which many still believe has been visited precisely because of its alliance with the US. The attacks have grown not just in daring but in brutality and reach. Believed to be triggered by the loosely termed 'Pakistan Taliban' and Al-Qaeda elements, they have previously specifically targeted security forces and installations but now seem to be mindlessly going after civilians. Even *Dawn's* editorial acknowledged that "the state is floundering in the face of an unprecedented wave of violence".

Concerned by the alarming spread of Taliban-like militancy, the Pakistan Army has mounted a decisive battle in the remote tribal region of South Waziristan—codenamed Rah-i-Nijaat (Path of Deliverance)—to go after what it terms "the centre of gravity" of terrorism in Pakistan. Around 30,000 troops are now deployed in South Waziristan alone, backed by heavy artillery, tanks, helicopter gunships and F-16 jets. The military has long claimed that the "roots of most terror attacks in the country and militancy in other areas" are in the Mehsud tribal area of the semi-autonomous agency. It claims that it is battling some 10,000 hardened fighters here, including some 1,000-1,500 mostly Uzbek foreign militants, allied with the Tehrik-e-Taliban Pakistan (TTP) of Baitullah Mehsud who was killed in a US drone attack on August 5 and who had been on top of Pakistan's most-wanted list for many years. Officials claim that the area serves as a refuge and training ground for militants from all over Pakistan—including the so-called 'Punjabi Taliban'—as well as Al-Qaeda-linked foreign militants.

And as if matters were not critical enough, Pakistan's politics is undergoing the sort of period of nervous doubt the short democratic history of the country is replete with. At its centre is a growing distrust and disconnect between the establishment, especially the army, and President Asif Ali Zardari. The rumour mill is ripe with specu-

tion that it is the beginning of the end for the Pakistan Peoples Party (PPP) co-chairman, especially after it looks increasingly unlikely that the controversial National Reconciliation Ordinance (NRO) will be ratified by Parliament. Without that law in place, all of the corruption allegations against the President and his cronies—many of them in powerful positions in government now—could be reopened. The

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speculation centres around whether Zardari will be the only one to go or will take down the system with him.

For an economy hit by the global recession, power shortages and high inflation, the current uncertainty about security and the political situation has been nothing less than a death knell. Marketplaces and restaurants in most of Pakistan—except for Karachi, ironically spared an attack so far—wear a deserted look and the paranoia is almost palpable. The spate of attacks and Pakistan's precarious security situation has fanned anxiety in world capitals, including Delhi, about the capacity of Pakistan to withstand such relentless terror. The big worry: Can Pakistan be saved? The nightmarish scenario for the world is a nuclear-armed Pakistan going the Afghanistan way and ending up as a dangerously splintered and Talibanised nation.

That is why the do-or-die battle that the Pakistan Army is fighting in the tribal areas is critical to its survival. And it is the reason the Pakistani public has never been more committed to uprooting militancy from its soil with